

THE GARAMUT



A MESSAGE SENDER

*Ps Barry's
Reflections on:*
**PRAYER,
PROCLAMATION and
PERSONAL PROGRESS**

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YOU PREPARE A TABLE BEFORE ME IN THE PRESENCE OF MY ENEMIES

Psalms 23:5 Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies: thou anointest my head with oil; my cup runneth over. KJV

Psalms 23:5 Thou arrange before me a table, Over-against my adversaries, Thou hast anointed with oil my head, My cup is full! YLT

THOU PREPAREST A TABLE FOR ME IN THE PRESENCE OF MINE ENEMIES - Psalm 23:5

- Here are some factors to be considered in what this verse means.
- This verse is about God's promise of protection and provision even when circumstances that **are hostile** and in the midst of those who wish them harm.
- God's goodness and care for the sheep providing for them.
- Psalm 23:5 Carries the assurance that the Lord protects His sheep and fills their days with His blessings.

Example

THE BASQUE SHEPHERDS

"David's meaning is a simple one," said D'Alphonso, "when conditions on the Holy Land sheep ranges are known. Poisonous plants abound that are fatal to grazing animals. Each spring the shepherd must be constantly alert. When he finds the plants, he takes his mattock and goes on ahead of the flock, grubbing out every stock and root he can see. As he digs out the stocks, he lays them upon little stone pyres, some of which were built by shepherds in Old Testament days, and by the morrow they are dry enough to burn. In the meantime, the sheep are led into the newly prepared pasture, which is now free from poisonous plants, and, in the presence of their deadly plant enemies, they eat in peace."

NOTE: The shepherds would remove the poisonous or harmful weeds from the pasture where his sheep would be feeding.

- ♦ **WHAT A BEAUTIFUL PICTURE** of our great shepherd and bishop of our souls – Jesus preparing nourishment and sustenance for us right in the midst of those enemies that would seek to cripple our faith, to lie with the aim of confusing us and discouraging us from continuing on because of our past failures.
- ♦ These enemies are thieves and robbers and seek to kill and destroy our spiritual life and especially our love for Christ our great Shepherd - *John 10:10 The thief 's purpose is to steal, kill and destroy. My purpose is to give life in all its fullness. TLB*
- ♦ **BUT GOD secretly knows how to feed us** and pour in his strength and encouragement as well as preserve us from all evil.
Psalms 121:7 The Lord shall preserve you from all evil; He shall preserve your soul. NKJV
Psalms 121:7 The Lord will keep you from all harm — he will watch over your life; NIV
- ♦ **DAVID** the shepherd King celebrates the **protection and provision of God.**
- ♦ **Sheep guarded by a skilled shepherd** are led to food and water and protected from harm.
- ♦ **The knowledge of God's protection and provision** are a great comfort. Psalm 23 incorporates themes of supply, defence, assurance, and care from God.

MY PERSONAL TESTIMONY

During the 30-year civil war that raged in Sri Lanka between the two opposing armies and I travelled between their respective regions and areas that they each controlled. I spent between 8 to 10 weeks every year split into two or three visits. While in Sri Lanka we daily faced (the team accompanying me) to military check points from the military where all of our vehicle would be thoroughly searched and if they were suspicious, they would strip the inside linings of the vehicle. All of our luggage was pulled out and searched for any items that could of use to the opposing side. This procedure would happen 8 - 10 times in one day. Also, there were land mines lining both sides of the roads for many kilometers, and often artillery shelling at both day and nights and there was always the possibility of being caught in the cross fire in close proximity of the roads that we had to travel on. There was always the constant tension of the unexpected as there were bombs regularly planted in parked motorbikes, vehicles, shops, along the roadside and the possibility of a suicide bombers blowing themselves up. But in all the years of travelling throughout Sri Lanka, I had no fear and no harm came to me. Regardless of all the things that were happening around us fear was not there – it was absent. I cannot explain it apart from God and his angels having arranged it because there was nothing to do with me. However, prior to my first ministry trip into Sri Lanka, the Spirit spoke very clearly to me from *Acts 18:10 - For I am with thee, and no man shall set on thee to hurt thee: for I have much people in this city. (KJV)* *Acts 18:10 For I am with you, and no one will lay a hand on you to hurt you, because I have many people in this city." Holman*

◆ NO FEAR AND NO HARM

It was like God he prepared a table before / for me in the presence of my enemies.

ANOTHER EXAMPLE - AS THE LILY AMONGST THORNS.

Song of Solomon 2:2 LIKE A LILY AMONG THORNS IS MY DARLING (the lady) among the maidens. NIV
Song of Solomon 2:2 AS A LILY AMONG THORNS, SO IS MY LOVE (the lady) among the daughters beloved WEB

- ◆ **I THINK OF** the lily that is amongst thorns and how the lily surrounded by thorns and thistles, a **hostile environment** did not affect the ladies' growth and beauty and her ability to attract her lover.
- ◆ **HE SAYS** **she has ravished / stolen my heart** *Songs 4:9.*
- ◆ **SHE IS** much more beautiful, appealing and captivating than all other women.
- ◆ **HER BEAUTY STANDS OUT ABOVE HER ENVIRONMENT** (**thorns / thistles**) and is the Centre of attraction for her man *Songs 2:2.*

What do **thorns** symbolize in the Bible?

- ◆ In the Garden of Eden, one of the first symbols and symptoms of the curse brought upon mankind because of Adam's sin – was the presence of "thorns and thistles" to represent the pain and toil connected to man's labour from then on (Genesis 3:18).
Genesis 3:17-19 - "Cursed is the ground because of you; through painful toil you will eat of it all the days of your life. 18 It will produce thorns and thistles for you, and you will eat the plants of the field. 19 By the sweat of your brow you will eat your Food"... NIV

THORNS and THISTLES

- ◆ **BECAUSE** they are part of the curse of the ground and the thorns and thistles seek to **compete** for the **same nourishment** of the ground that the lily lies. They endeavor **to choke** the life of the wildflowers / the lily and so try to restrict their growth and beauty.
- ◆ **They seek to dominate and control by virtue proliferation of thorns to outnumber the flowers.**
- ◆ **Yet the lily outshines** the thorns.
- ◆ **THIS IS ANOTHER EXAMPLE OUR GOD** who prepared a table of nourishment, provision and protection for the lily **to abound in beauty in every increasing vitality** right in the midst of her enemy's – the thorns and thistles
- ◆ **AND GOD STILL DOES THAT TODAY.**
- ◆ **SO, EVERY BELIEVER TAKE HEART BECAUSE GOD WILL CAUSE YOU TO GROW AND BLOSSOM IN BEAUTY IN EVERY ADVERSE AND HOSTILE CIRCUMSTANCE.**

Amen – Ps Barry